In order to track down and eliminate ‘hostile-negative elements’, MfS functionaries penetrated all areas of life, building-up dossiers on the entire population (More than 100 miles of files were amassed in Berlin alone). Unofficial collaborators were recruited to spy on neighbours, workmates and friends. Known as ‘IMs’, collaborators reported what was happening in companies, at universities, in the arts, medicine and sport, or even in their own family circles. In a number of cases, ‘IMs’ infiltrated opposition circles and provided information about colleagues or fellow students.15 Over time, Stasi agents were even able to listen in to telephone conversations at NATO headquarters with no difficulty, and – using state-of-the-art snooping techniques – they could eavesdrop on any telephone call in Europe. As the MfS pulled in suspects, the judiciary assumed a dominating role. The Minister of Justice, Hilde Benjamin, known as ‘Red Bide’, oversaw numerous show trials against agents and saboteurs, working under the slogan ‘no impartiality towards the enemies of the State’.

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* The principal policy-making and executive